

1947 Independence of the Indian subcontinent begins the dismemberment of the British Empire.

1948 National Health Service establishes free medical treatment for all.

1949 Founding member of NATO.

1951 The Festival of Britain provides relief from post-war austerity measures.

1951 Conservatives return to power.

1952 Elizabeth II becomes queen.

1956 Suez crisis: UK and France collude with Israel to invade Egypt but are forced out under US pressure.

1957 UK grants independence to Ghana, its first African colony to be decolonized. By 1980, almost all former British colonies gain their independence.

1973 UK joins the European Economic Community (EEC, now EU).

1975 First North Sea oil is piped ashore.

1979 Margaret Thatcher becomes first British woman prime minister and holds power until 1990; she ushers in 18 years of Conservative government.

1982 Argentina invades Falkland Islands, which are retaken by a UK task force.

1986 Financial services deregulated in “Big Bang” as British economy booms.

1990 Rioters in London protest against the Poll Tax, which replaced rates to finance local councils. Thatcher is toppled by her party and replaced by John Major.

1997 Landslide election victory for Labour Party under Tony Blair.

1999 Devolution gives Scotland its own parliament and Wales its own assembly.

2001 Labour wins a second term with a huge majority and goes on to win a third in 2005. The UK joins the US in the invasion of Afghanistan after the 9/11 terror attacks against the US.

2003 UK and the US invade Iraq and overthrow Saddam Hussein, a move that is hugely divisive in Britain.

2005 On July 7, four Al-Qaeda inspired militants detonate bombs on the London Underground and on a London bus, killing 52 passengers.

2007 Blair stands down as prime minister and Gordon Brown replaces him.

2008 The global economic crisis hits Britain badly. The government is forced to nationalize the Northern Rock building society in February and in October the HSBC and Lloyds TSB banks are taken under majority government control. The additional government expenditure sees Britain's budget deficit rise to 11.4 percent of GDP by 2010.

UNITED KINGDOM

NORTHERN IRELAND

Northern Ireland consists of six counties in the north of Ireland that remained part of the UK when the 26 southern counties became independent. The province is often called Ulster, one of the four ancient kingdoms of Ireland.

1920 Government of Ireland Act partitions Ireland, with a Protestant north.

1921 Northern Irish parliament first meets.

1969 Widespread rioting after Protestants attack Catholic districts: British army is deployed as violence erupts across the province, marking the start of “the Troubles.”

1972 Northern Irish parliament suspended; direct British rule imposed.

1985 Anglo-Irish agreement between Britain and Ireland to work for peace.

1998 Good Friday agreement sets up a devolved assembly.

2005 IRA declares armed struggle is over.

2007 DUP and Sinn Féin agree to share power; devolved assembly finally meets.



Orange Marching Season

Every July 12, members of the Protestant Orange Order march to commemorate the Battle of the Boyne in 1691, when Protestant William of Orange defeated Catholic James II.

2010 General election: With no overall majority, the Conservative leader David Cameron negotiates a formal coalition with the Liberal Democrats.

«192–93 The Battle of Hastings

«264–65 The English Civil War

«292–93 The Industrial Revolution

«348–49 Queen Victoria

«412–13 End of the Colonial Era

Ireland



Centuries of struggle against English rule brought independence for most of Ireland in 1922.

c.300 BCE Ireland is invaded by Gaelic-speaking Celts.

432 CE Christianity is introduced to Ireland by St. Patrick (c.389–461), who becomes the country's patron saint.

795 First Viking raid on Ireland; the Vikings settle along the coast, founding Dublin in 811.

1014 At the battle of Clontarf, Viking power is broken and the four traditional Irish kingdoms of Ulster, Leinster, Munster, and Connaught are briefly united under Brian Boru.

1171 During the reign of English king Henry II (1154–89), Anglo-Norman adventurers conquer parts of Ireland, having received authorization from Pope Adrian IV (an Englishman) to subjugate Ireland. By the 1175 Treaty of Windsor, the High King of Ireland recognizes the English King as his overlord.

1264 First meeting of Irish parliament.

1494 Under the terms of Poynings' Law, English laws apply to Ireland.

1541 Having broken the power of Ireland's feudal lords, Henry VIII (1509–47) adopts the title of King of Ireland.

1559–1607 Against the backdrop of attempts by Elizabeth I (1558–1603) to impose Protestantism, a succession of unsuccessful rebellions against the English are launched in Ulster (1559–66, 1593–1603) and Munster (1569–72). In 1607, 100 Irish Catholic lords flee to Rome. Scottish Presbyterian settlers move to Ulster, taking land from Irish Catholics.

1609 First Ulster plantations created.

1641 Catholics launch a rebellion against English rule which is eventually crushed at Drogheda in 1649 by Oliver Cromwell.

1652 Act of Settlement displaces Irish Catholics to poor land in Connaught.

1690 Irish Catholics who support the deposed English Catholic king James II (1685–88) are defeated by William of Orange at the Battle of the Boyne.

1704 Under the terms of a new penal code, Catholics are deprived of the right to acquire property and in 1728 the right to vote. The “Protestant Ascendancy” lasts for most of the 18th century.

1778 Irish MP Henry Grattan secures the removal of most anti-Catholic land laws.

1795 Ulster Protestants set up the Loyal Orange Institution—the Orange Order—to defend land rights against Catholics.

1798 United Irishmen rebellion against British rule, led by Wolfe Tone, crushed.

1801 The Act of Union between Great Britain and Ireland comes into force. The Irish parliament is abolished and Ireland obtains representation at the Westminster parliament. Catholics are not allowed to sit in the House of Commons until 1829.

1845–51 Famine. One million die and more than one million emigrate.

1858 Irish Republican Brotherhood, or Fenians, formed to fight for an independent Irish republic.

1869 Irish church disestablished.

1870 First land reform act begins to tackle issues of absentee landlords, lack of tenant security, and unfair rents.

1882 Irish MPs in London form the Irish Parliamentary Party to fight for home rule.

1896, 1893 Home Rule Bills to give Ireland its own parliament are defeated.

1905 Sinn Féin founded.

1912 An attempt to introduce new Home Rule Bill brings Ireland to the brink of civil war as unionists and nationalists set up armed militias.

1916 Easter Rising in Dublin by the Irish Republican Brotherhood soon crushed. The British execute the leaders, increasing support for the Republican cause.

1918 Sinn Féin wins landslide in general election; its MPs do not take their seats but set up independent Dáil Éireann (Assembly of Ireland) in Dublin and declare Irish independence in 1919.

1919–21 Anglo-Irish war between Irish Republican Army (IRA) and British army.

1921 Anglo-Irish Treaty sets up Irish Free State in 1922, with six northern counties in the UK.

1922–23 Civil war between pro- and anti-Treaty forces.

1937 Full sovereignty as Éire.

1949 Éire becomes Republic of Ireland and leaves the British Commonwealth.

1973 Ireland joins the EEC (now EU).

1990 Mary Robinson elected first woman president.

1995 Referendum favors divorce.

2002 Ireland adopts the euro.

2008 Voters reject the Lisbon Treaty causing a crisis in the EU. The treaty is passed in a second referendum in 2009.

2009 Global economic crisis affects Ireland badly, with unemployment reaching 11 percent.

2010 Ireland accepts EU and IMF bailout of its banking system, amounting to 85 billion euros. Prime Minister Brian Cowen calls early general election, won the following year by Fine Gael, which enters coalition with Labour Party.

«134–35 Celtic Warriors
«436–37 “The Troubles”